Free Federal Retirement Checklist

A step-by-step guide for FERS employees, based on OPM.gov guidance. For more information, visit paduaco.com.

1. Ways to Retire

OPM sorts FERS retirement into four types: Immediate, Early, Deferred and Disability. Your age and years of service decide which one you get.

Find your Minimum Retirement Age (MRA)

Born in	Your MRA
Before 1948	55
1948	55 + 2 months
1949	55 + 4 months
1950	55 + 6 months
1951	55 + 8 months
1952	55 + 10 months
1953 to 1964	56
1965	56 + 2 months
1966	56 + 4 months
1967	56 + 6 months
1968	56 + 8 months
1969	56 + 10 months
1970 or later	57

- ☐ **Step 1:** Find your MRA in the table. It is between 55 and 57, based on your birth year.
- ☐ **Step 2:** Compare your age and years of service to the chart below.
- ☐ **MRA+10** pays you right away, but your annuity is cut 5% for each year you are under 62. You can postpone the start date to make the cut smaller.
- ☐ **Early retirement** (agency reorganization, reduction in force or VERA): age 50 with 20 years, or any age with 25 years.
- ☐ **Left before you were eligible?** You may get a deferred annuity at 62 (5 years) or at MRA (10 years). Do not take a refund of your contributions.
- ☐ **Disability:** OPM must receive your application within 1 year of leaving.

Your age	Years of service	What you get
62	5	Full annuity
60	20	Full annuity
MRA	30	Full annuity
MRA	10 to 29	Reduced 5% for each year under 62 (MRA+10). You can postpone to shrink the cut.
50	20	Early retirement only (reorganization, reduction in force or VERA)
Any age	25	Early retirement only (reorganization, reduction in force or VERA)

2. FEHB: What Happens to Your Health Insurance

The 5-year rule

5 years

of FEHB coverage in a row, right before you retire

AND you retire on an immediate annuity (MRA+10 counts).

- ☐ Confirm you have **5 years in a row** of FEHB coverage. Coverage under a family member's FEHB plan counts. TRICARE or CHAMPVA time counts too, but you must be in an FEHB plan on your retirement date.
- ☐ Do not drop FEHB in those 5 years. A gap can restart the clock.
- ☐ Keep your own copies of your FEHB forms (SF 2809 and SF 2810). Missing proof of coverage is a common reason applications get delayed.
- ☐ **MRA+10:** health and life coverage are on hold until your annuity starts, even if you postpone it.
- ☐ Missed the 5-year rule? OPM can waive it only in exceptional cases. A voluntary retiree can usually keep working until the rule is met, so a waiver is unlikely.
- ☐ After you retire, you can switch plans only during the yearly Open Season.

3. FEGLI: Getting Basic Life Insurance Free at 65

Pick one on Form SF 2818

Basic choice at retirement	After 65
75% Reduction	**FREE.** Coverage drops 2% a month until 25% is left.
50% Reduction	Extra premium for life. Coverage drops to 50%.
No Reduction	Larger extra premium for life. Coverage stays at 100%.

No election = you get 75% Reduction.

- ☐ Confirm you had FEGLI for the **5 years in a row** before you retire. You must keep Basic to keep Option A, B or C.
- ☐ On Form SF 2818, choose **75% Reduction**. Basic is free once the reductions begin. Until you reach 65, you still pay the regular Basic premium.
- ☐ Option A drops automatically after 65 and is free. For Options B and C, choose **Full Reduction** on the multiples you want free after 65. No Reduction multiples keep costing you.
- ☐ Around **age 55**, use OPM's FEGLI Calculator to check your coverage and decide whether to lower it. Optional premiums rise in 5-year age bands, and OPM says you can reduce or cancel anytime.

4. TSP: Saving Toward $1 Million

Rule of thumb

20%

of your salary, saved each year, may reach about **$1 million**

Approximate. Not a guarantee. Not from OPM.

- ☐ Check what percent of your pay you put into TSP now.
- ☐ If you are below about 20%, raise it. Your results depend on your salary, how many years you save and investment returns.
- ☐ Review your TSP statement at least once a year.

5. The Retirement Process: Start 3 Months Ahead

Timeline

When	What
3 months before	Pick your exact date. Talk to HR.
At least 60 days before	Agency needs this long to process (some need more).
Retirement date	You retire. Do not resign first.

- ☐ About **3 months before**, choose your exact date (month, day, year). OPM suggests at least 2 to 3 months out.
- ☐ Contact your agency HR or benefits office.
- ☐ **Do not resign.** Your signed retirement application is your resignation. If you leave first and die before filing, your survivors get no life insurance, survivor annuity or survivor health coverage.
- ☐ Use your personal phone, email and address on the forms (not work ones). Sign every form. No cross-outs or white-out.
- ☐ Fill out SF 2818 on the computer, then print, sign and date it.
- ☐ Make sure your Official Personnel Folder shows your full service history.
- ☐ Turning 65 soon? Contact Social Security at least 3 months before your birthday about Medicare.

6. Need More Help?

For more information, visit **paduaco.com**.

Sources

- OPM: Types of Retirement (FERS)
- OPM: FERS Eligibility
- OPM: FERS Election Options (MRA table)
- OPM: FEHB Annuitants
- OPM: Health benefits and retirement FAQ
- OPM: FEGLI Basic in retirement FAQ
- OPM: FEGLI Calculator
- OPM: Planning and Applying
- OPM: Planning for retirement FAQ
- OPM: Application tips

Important: The TSP figure in section 4 is a general rule of thumb and does not come from OPM. This checklist is general information, not personal advice. Confirm your own eligibility with your agency HR office.